fifty people and a severe drought hits our home territory, many of us might starve to death. If we try to migrate elsewhere, we are likely to encounter hostile groups, and we might also find it difficult to forage for food, water and flint (to make tools) in unfamiliar territory. However, if our band is part of a tribal network, in times of need at least some of us could go to live with our distant friends. If our shared tribal identity is strong enough, they would welcome us and teach us about the local dangers and opportunities. A decade or two later, we might reciprocate. The tribal network, then, acted like an insurance policy. It minimised risk by spreading it across a lot more people.[21]

Even in quiet times Sapiens could benefit enormously from exchanging information not just with a few dozen members of a small band but with an entire tribal network. If one of the tribe's bands discovered a better way to make spear points, learned how to heal wounds with some rare medicinal herb or invented a needle to sew clothes, that knowledge could be quickly passed to the other bands. Even though individually Sapiens might not have been more intelligent than Neanderthals, five hundred Sapiens together were far more intelligent than fifty Neanderthals.[22]

All this was made possible by stories. The power of stories is often missed or denied by materialist interpretations of history. In particular, Marxists tend to view stories as merely a smoke screen for underlying power relations and material interests. According to Marxist theories, people are always motivated by objective material interests and use stories only to camouflage these interests and confound their rivals. For example, in this reading the Crusades, the First World War and the Iraq War were all fought for the economic interests of powerful elites rather than for religious, nationalist or liberal ideals. Understanding these wars means setting aside all the mythological fig leaves – about God, patriotism or democracy – and observing power relations in their nakedness.

This Marxist view, however, is not only cynical but wrong. While materialist interests certainly played a role in the Crusades, the First World War, the Iraq War and most other human conflicts, that does not mean that religious, national and liberal ideals played no role at all. Moreover, materialist interests by themselves cannot explain the identities of the rival camps. Why is it that in the twelfth century landowners and merchants from France, Germany and Italy united to conquer territories and trade routes in the Levant – instead of landowners and merchants from France and North